

Mixed Conditionals

B2 · Upper-Intermediate · Combine a past condition with a present result, or a present condition with a past result.

Real regrets and hypotheticals often mix time frames — a past decision affecting the present, or a permanent truth affecting a past event. Mixed conditionals let you express that precisely.

Rules

a) Past condition → present result

If + past perfect, would + base verb. A past action (or its opposite) explains a present situation.

- If I had studied medicine, I would be a doctor now. (I didn't study medicine, so I'm not a doctor now)

b) Present condition → past result

If + past simple, would have + past participle. A permanent truth/characteristic explains a past event.

- If she weren't so shy, she would have spoken up at the meeting. (she is shy — a permanent trait — and that's why she didn't speak up, in the past)

Examples

- If I had studied medicine, I would be a doctor now.
- If she weren't so shy, she would have spoken up at the meeting.
- If he hadn't missed the flight, he would be here with us now.
- If I were more organized, I wouldn't have forgotten the meeting.
- If they had saved more money, they wouldn't be struggling now.
- If you weren't so stubborn, you would have accepted their help.

Common Mistakes

✗ If I had studied medicine, I would have been a doctor now.

✓ If I had studied medicine, I would be a doctor now.

"Now" signals a present result — use "would be," not "would have been."

× If she wasn't so shy, she would have spoken up.

✓ If she weren't so shy, she would have spoken up.

The second-conditional "if" clause uses "were," not "was," for all subjects.

× If he hadn't missed the flight, he would have been here now.

✓ If he hadn't missed the flight, he would be here now.

A present result ("now") needs "would be," not "would have been."

Summary

- Past condition → present result: If + past perfect, would + base verb.
- Present condition → past result: If + past simple, would have + past participle.
- Look for a time-clue word like "now" to tell you the result is present, not past.

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